Iraq fights back and emerges from isolation

Key question
How did Iraq emerge from international isolation?

Saddam did not want to give up all his secret weapons and had always tried to disrupt the UN weapons inspectors. Besides, he knew that the inspection teams were working closely with the **CIA** and other Western intelligence agencies. He no doubt suspected that they were planning to overthrow him. In 1996, the new, Australian leader of the UNSCOM inspection team demanded access, with no advance warning given, to the headquarters of the special security services and to the presidential palaces. Saddam refused and, in 1997, the UNSCOM inspectors were forced to leave Iraq. A year later, in 1998, American (and British) planes started bombing Iraqi military sites despite the commonly held view that Iraq had no more WMD.

Key dates

Election of George W. Bush as US President: 2000

Attack on the World Trade Center in New York: 2001

Most Arab states had been happy to see Iraq taught a lesson in 1991 but now the bombing campaign turned many of them against the USA. When the US Secretary of State Madeleine Albright was asked on television if the starvation of half a million people was justified, she said it had been 'worth it'. This caused widespread anger in the Arab world and several states started to trade with Iraq again. Saudi Arabia and Kuwait still provided the US with bases from which to launch bombing raids on Iraq but there was an increasing amount of oil smuggling across Iraq's borders with Syria, Iran and Turkey, which the UN could not control. Iraq was re-emerging from international isolation.

Key term

CIA
The US Central Intelligence Agency, responsible for gathering information about foreign governments for the US government.

Even the USA seemed to accept the revival of Iraq's oil industry. A growing global economy was pushing up oil prices and several American firms won contracts to rebuild Iraq's oil wells. By 1999 the UN had approved unlimited oil exports from Iraq and Saddam's regime had restored diplomatic relations with all its neighbours. It had got rid of the hated UN inspectors and still had the most feared army in the Arab world. Saddam had challenged the UN, and the world's one and only superpower, and had survived. When George W. Bush was elected President of the USA in 2000, there was renewed talk in Washington of the need to 'remove Saddam'.

Background to invasion

Key question
Why did the USA launch an invasion of Iraq in 2003?

Ten years after the First Gulf War, Saddam Hussein was still defiant and still in control of the country with the world's second largest oil reserves. Many members of the new US government regretted that American forces had not removed Saddam in 1991. They believed he was a threat to the whole region and, in particular, to US interests in the Middle East. Plans for an invasion were drawn up: now that Iraq was weakened by sanctions, it would put up less resistance while there was no rival superpower to check the USA or come to Iraq's defence. Then, in September 2001, came the attack on the World Trade Center in New York and the Pentagon in Washington and the US diverted its attention to Afghanistan (see pages 148–9).